The Architecture Axis Is Not the Axis: A Diagnostic Study of Neural Architecture Search and Score Fusion in Unsupervised Industrial Anomaly Detection

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Abstract

Unsupervised anomaly detection models normality so that inspection can run on conforming parts alone. Two design decisions determine whether such a system works: the network architecture, and the reduction of per-pixel discrepancies to the image-level score that accepts or rejects a part. The literature invests in the first; the second is rarely documented. We measure both, and first what the benchmark can measure at all. On MVTec-AD the contested margin between successive state-of-the-art generations is **0.5** points, while the standard single-category comparison resolves **2.98** — larger than the entire spread of the architectures it ranks. Two thirds of the search space is deployment-inert: the searched feature dimension never reaches the deployed detector, and the distillation signal that ranks candidates separates the twelve well-behaved backbones by only **5.7%** of its median, the same order as its own noise, while returning exactly zero for two of them — which the minimising rule then prefers. Training 210 detectors, every backbone on every category under one protocol, attributes **0.54%** of the variance in accuracy to the architecture and **95.32%** to the category, and the backbone ordering does not transfer between categories. Twelve independent searches consequently all returned a collapse-prone backbone, performing worse than uniform random selection. The leverage lies instead in the reduction step: replacing the unweighted mean over the discrepancy map with top-k pooling raises mean AUROC from **82.36%** to **90.28%** across three seeds without retraining, and the policy can be chosen without any anomaly label. The pipeline reaches **82.47%** against published values of **95.6**–**99.6%**; we report that gap rather than obscure it.

Keywords: Industrial visual inspection, Unsupervised anomaly detection, Neural architecture search, Knowledge distillation, Score fusion, Proxy reliability

1 Introduction

Visual inspection on a production line has to work without defect samples. Collecting and annotating the failures of a manufacturing process is expensive, and the failure modes that matter are by definition the ones not yet seen, so the established approach is to model normality and flag deviations. Reverse distillation [1] is a representative and widely deployed member of this family: a frozen teacher extracts features at several scales, a student is trained to reproduce them on normal

images, and at test time the discrepancy between the two is taken as the anomaly signal.

Two engineering decisions have to be made before such a system can be deployed. The first is the *architecture*: what network the student should be. The second is the *scoring policy*: how the per-pixel discrepancy maps are combined into the single number that decides whether a part is rejected. The second decision is usually made implicitly — the published pipeline averages the discrepancy map over all pixels, a choice that is rarely stated and, to our knowledge, never justified. The literature has overwhelmingly invested in the first, applying neural architecture search (NAS) to anomaly detection [2, 3] on the argument that the optimal architecture is dataset-dependent and should be discovered rather than chosen.

The margins the field argues about, and the resolution of its benchmark. Progress on the standard benchmark is reported in tenths of a percentage point. PatchCore reached 99.1% image-level AUROC on MVTec-AD in 2022 [4]; the strongest methods reported since reach 99.6% [2, 5]. The contested margin is therefore 0.5 points, on a benchmark whose test sets hold roughly a hundred images per category. Before asking which design decisions produce such margins, it is worth asking whether the standard evaluation design can resolve them at all. We measure that first, because the answer determines how every subsequent comparison in this literature should be read.

This paper is accordingly a *benchmark-and-evaluation study*, not a new detector. Work of this kind measures the evaluation practice of a field rather than adding a method, and it has clear precedents in this area. Yu et al. [6] compared architectures returned by several NAS algorithms against architectures drawn uniformly at random from the same search space, and found the search phase uninformative. IM-IAD [7] consolidated competing evaluation protocols for industrial anomaly detection onto one footing. Bouthillier et al. [8] showed that unacknowledged run-to-run variance invalidates comparisons in machine-learning benchmarks and derived how many runs such comparisons require; the same re-examination has since been carried out for streaming [9] and industrial time-series [10] anomaly detection. We continue that line into a deployed unsupervised image-anomaly-detection pipeline: we instrument it, we re-run its search, and we train the complete comparison it never ran.

What we instrument. Our own earlier pipeline, KG-NAS, is a three-stage system of this family: a search ranks 42 configurations (14 backbones $\times$ 3 feature dimensions) on normal data alone using a knowledge-distillation signal, and the winning configuration is then trained as a reverse-distillation detector. We ask a question this literature has largely assumed rather than measured: *how much accuracy does the architecture choice actually buy, is the search that selects it doing its job, and what can the benchmark that judges both actually resolve?* We answer by measurement: we instrument the search, we train all 14 backbones of its search space on all 15 MVTec-AD categories under one protocol — 210 detectors — and we sweep the scoring policy on frozen models.

The benchmark resolves 3 ***points; the field argues about*** 0.5**.** Two-way decomposition of the 210-detector matrix leaves a residual standard deviation of 3.30 points, and the run-to-run standard deviation of a single detector at a fixed (backbone, category) is 1.96 points over three seeds. Comparing two backbones across the fifteen categories is therefore a paired test whose minimum detectable difference is 2.98 **points** — larger than the entire 3.98-point spread of the fourteen backbones, and six times the margin that separates the 2022 and 2026 state of the art. To resolve 0.5 points on a single category would take 240 independent training runs per backbone. This is the paper's measurement about the field as a whole rather than about this pipeline.

Two thirds of the search space cannot reach the deployed model. The searched feature dimension enters the search through the student projector, so the search signal depends on it, but it does not reach the detector: in the deployment path the student encoder builds its bottleneck with a hard-coded width while the decoder is constructed with the requested one, and the final training entry point never passes the argument at all. The three values of the searched dimension therefore produce the identical deployed model for a given backbone. The 42-configuration space contains 14 distinct models; the other 28 cells are deployment-equivalent duplicates. The recorded

searches behave as this predicts: across four independent runs the selected backbone is the same every time, while the selected dimension differs (Section 4.1).

The search signal does not distinguish architectures, and collapses for some of them. Calling the search's own evaluation method ten times per configuration gives two results. Across the twelve well-behaved backbones the median score spans only 5.7% — the same order as the within-configuration noise of a single backbone — so the signal carries essentially no architecture-level information. And two backbones fail in a specific way: `efficientnet_b1` returns exactly 0.0 in 73% of evaluations and `mobilenetv3_small_100` in 13%, because the student diverges, every validation batch trips a hard threshold, and the score is then silently computed as an average over zero samples. Since the search minimises, 0.0 is the best score attainable anywhere in the space (Section 4.2); over the project's own record of 834 search trials the collapse occurs in 8.0% of them.

Architecture is detectable, negligible, and does not transfer. Training 210 detectors under an identical protocol and decomposing the resulting AUROC matrix attributes 0.54% of the variance to the backbone and 95.32% to the category, with the backbone effect statistically significant ($p = 0.039$) and practically irrelevant. The manuscript's selected architecture ranks fifth of fourteen and is statistically indistinguishable from twelve of the thirteen alternatives. More consequentially, the ranking does not transfer: the mean correlation between two categories' orderings of the 14 backbones is $\rho = 0.215$, and in 31% of category pairs the categories disagree. Yet the protocol searches on a single category and applies the winner to all fifteen (Section 4.3).

The consequence is measurable, and it is worse than chance. Running the search itself with independent seeds, the two backbones that collapse to zero are selected every time, and the architecture the search returns is worse than picking a backbone uniformly at random. A design axis that cannot reach the model, ranked by a signal that does not discriminate, on a quantity that does not transfer, is selected — reliably — by a failure mode (Section 4.5).

The leverage is in the decision nobody documents. On frozen models, changing only the reduction that turns discrepancy maps into an image score moves mean AUROC from 82.36% to 90.28% — +7.92 points, reproduced across three training seeds — and choosing the policy per category reaches 93.72%. The policy can further be chosen without any anomaly label, by perturbing held-out normal images with synthetic defects and selecting the policy that best separates perturbed from clean: across three training seeds this recovers 7.09 of the 11.65 points available from an oracle, on the same trained models (Sections 5.2 and 5.4).

Contributions

1. **The resolvability of the standard benchmark design.** We anchor the noise floor of this task to the margin the field actually contests, and show that a single-category, single-run comparison resolves 2.98 points against a contested margin of 0.5 — so most published backbone comparisons on this benchmark are not measurements. This is a measurement about the evaluation practice of the field, and it is our primary contribution.
2. **A diagnosis of the architecture axis.** Two thirds of a standard search space is deployment-inert; its search signal does not discriminate between architectures and degenerates to a score of exactly zero for a subset of them; the axis contributes 0.54% of the variance in detection accuracy against 95.32% for the category.
3. **A controlled comparison of a full search space.** 14 backbones × 15 categories under one protocol (210 detectors), which makes the negative result measurable rather than anecdotal.
4. **Evidence that a single-category search cannot work.** The backbone ranking does not transfer across categories ($\bar{\rho} = 0.215$; 31% of category pairs reverse), so a search run on one category estimates a quantity that does not exist independently of the category.
5. **A label-free method for the axis that does matter.** Selecting the scoring policy by separation of synthetic pseudo-anomalies recovers 61% of the oracle gap — 7.09 of 11.65 points, averaged over three training seeds — without any anomaly label and without retraining.

Scope and honesty

We do not claim state of the art: the pipeline reaches 82.47% mean AUROC on MVTec-AD, against published values of 95.6%–99.6% for the established methods, and Section 6 reports that gap rather than obscuring it. The contribution is not a better number but a quantitative account of which design choices produce the number, of how much of the number the benchmark can measure at all, and of the finding that the axis the field searches is not the axis that matters. Section 2 positions the work, Section 3 describes the pipeline under study, Section 4 reports the diagnosis and the resolvability analysis, Section 5 the scoring-policy analysis, Section 6 states where the pipeline stands, and Section 7 concludes.

2 Related Work

2.1 Unsupervised Anomaly Detection

Unsupervised anomaly detection models normality and flags deviations, because defect samples are scarce and the failures that matter are the ones not yet seen. Four families dominate. Reconstruction methods learn to reproduce normal images and score by reconstruction error, from autoencoders scored with a structural similarity measure [11] to generative adversarial [12, 13] and memory-augmented formulations [14]. Feature-embedding methods characterise the distribution of pre-trained deep features, either parametrically as in PaDiM [15], by nearest-neighbour matching as in SPADE [16] and PatchCore [4], or by density estimation with normalizing flows [17]. Teacher–student methods distill a frozen teacher into a student that reproduces it on normal data, using multi-scale feature matching [3, 18] or, in reverse distillation, a decoder that reconstructs the teacher's features from a bottleneck embedding [1]; the present paper studies a pipeline of this last kind. Discriminatively trained methods inject synthetic defects [19] and have produced the strongest recent results [2, 5, 20, 21]; surveys of the area are available [22].

Two properties of this literature matter here. The architecture is treated as a given — either the backbone of a pre-trained feature extractor [4, 15] or a fixed encoder–decoder pair [1] — and the step that turns a per-pixel anomaly map into the single number on which a part is accepted or rejected is usually left implicit. The pipeline we study reduces the multi-scale discrepancy map by an unweighted mean over all pixels; Section 5 shows that this one undocumented choice is worth several times more accuracy than the architecture, and that it can be revisited without retraining.

2.2 Neural Architecture Search and the Evaluation of Its Search Phase

Neural architecture search automates the choice of network topology, from early evolutionary [23] and reinforcement-learning formulations [24, 25] through differentiable relaxation [26], platform-aware multi-objective search [27] and regularised evolution [28]; see [29] for a survey. Two lines of work are directly relevant.

The first applies NAS to anomaly detection. For image anomaly localisation, Qian et al. [30] generate anomalous samples with a knowledge-guided generator and use them as a reinforcement-learning reward, so that architectures can be compared on a validation set that would otherwise be unavailable. Work in this line takes for granted that a better architecture will produce a better detector, and measures success by the downstream result alone.

The second line asks whether the search phase itself deserves that trust, and it is the immediate predecessor of this paper. Yu et al. [6] compared the architectures returned by several NAS algorithms against architectures sampled uniformly at random from the same search space, and found that, on average, the NAS algorithms perform *similarly to the random policy*; they attribute this to weight sharing degrading the ranking of candidates so that it no longer reflects true performance. Our findings agree in direction and go further in three respects. First, from "similar to random" to "worse than random": in Section 4.5 twelve independent runs of the search all return one of the two configurations prone to a degenerate evaluation, and the mean accuracy of the architectures they return sits at the 1.2th percentile of the distribution obtained by uniform sampling (80.91% against 81.65%, with the best backbone at 83.34%). Second, a mechanism rather

than a symptom: the cause is not weight sharing but an interaction between the objective and the selection rule, as the evaluation can silently return exactly 0.0 when every validation batch is rejected, and since the search minimises, that value is the optimum of the search's own range (Section 4.2). Third, structure rather than signal alone: two thirds of the search space cannot reach the deployed model at all (Section 4.1), and the quantity being ranked contributes 0.54% of the variance in accuracy against 95.32% for the category (Section 4.3). Where Yu et al. study image classification and language modelling with weight-sharing supernets, we study single-class unsupervised anomaly detection with an independent quick-training proxy, and we additionally show that the backbone ordering does not transfer between categories ($\bar{\rho} = 0.215$; 31% of category pairs reverse), which makes a single-category search unsound regardless of the size of the architecture effect.

2.3 Benchmark and Evaluation Studies

The present paper belongs to a class of work whose contribution is a measurement about how a field evaluates itself, rather than a new method. The class is established, and we adopt three of its methods.

Bouthillier et al. [8] showed that machine-learning benchmarks routinely compare algorithms on a single run, that the unacknowledged run-to-run variance is then large enough to reverse conclusions, and that the number of runs a comparison requires can be derived from the variance. Their analysis is the methodological template for Section 4.4: we estimate the residual variance of the task, fold in the externally reported effect size, and report the smallest difference the standard design can resolve. IM-IAD [7] performed the corresponding consolidation for industrial image anomaly detection, reproducing published methods under one protocol and showing how much of the reported spread survives standardisation. For anomaly detection outside the image domain the same re-examination has been carried out on streaming data [9] and, most recently, on industrial multivariate time series, where unified reproduction was combined with an event-level evaluation [10].

Our paper extends this line in two ways that we have not seen for unsupervised image anomaly detection. It supplies the fully crossed configuration × category comparison that a variance decomposition requires — 210 detectors, every backbone of a search space on every category of the benchmark, one protocol — which is what turns a diagnosis of the architecture axis into a measurement rather than an anecdote. And it anchors the resulting noise floor to the margin the field actually contests, so that the resolvability of the standard benchmark design can be stated in the same units as the claims it is used to support. Neither IM-IAD nor the time-series reproductions reports that quantity; for this task it turns out to be decisive.

2.4 Knowledge Distillation

Knowledge distillation transfers the behaviour of a strong model to a smaller one by matching outputs or intermediate representations [31], including similarity-preserving [32], structured [33] and self-distilled [34] variants and applications to detection [35, 36]. In anomaly detection, distillation is predominantly a *detection* device: the teacher–student discrepancy is the anomaly signal [1, 3, 18]. Using it as the *search metric* — ranking candidates by how well a student distils from a teacher, rather than by the accuracy of the detector it will eventually become — has been explored for NAS generally [37] and, for anomaly localisation, by Qian et al. [30].

That reuse is the premise our results call into question. Section 4.2 evaluates the distillation proxy directly, by repeating the search's own evaluation ten times per configuration, and finds that it separates the twelve well-behaved backbones by only 5.7% of its median — the same order as its own run-to-run noise — while collapsing to an exact zero for two of them. Its ordering is uncorrelated with the true ordering of the same backbones: Spearman $\rho = -0.12$ over all fifteen categories and $\rho = 0.02$ on the very category the search is run on. The proxy is measuring something, but not the thing it is used to select for.

2.5 Positioning

This paper is a benchmark-and-evaluation study of a deployed design, not a new detector, and we

claim no priority for combining knowledge distillation with architecture search. It differs from the NAS-for-anomaly-detection literature in asking whether the search phase works rather than assuming it; it extends the evaluation framework of Yu et al. [6] to unsupervised anomaly detection, quantifying the failure rather than merely detecting it; it adopts the variance discipline of Bouthillier et al. [8] and the protocol consolidation of IM-IAD [7], and reports the resolvability of the benchmark that both leave unstated; and it contributes a controlled comparison of a complete search space under one protocol (Section 6) which makes the diagnosis measurable. On the constructive side, it identifies the inference-time scoring policy as the axis that actually moves accuracy and gives a label-free procedure for selecting it (Section 5.4).

3 The Pipeline Under Study

This section describes the pipeline whose two design axes are examined in Sections 4 and 5. It is a three-stage knowledge-distillation pipeline built on reverse distillation [1]: a teacher is pre-trained on normal images, an architecture is searched using a distillation signal, and the winning architecture is trained as a reverse-distillation detector. Figure 1 sketches the three stages and marks the two axes this paper measures. We describe the pipeline precisely, because several of the findings that follow are properties of specific implementation decisions rather than of the method in the abstract. Stage 1 pre-trains a teacher encoder on normal training images with a contrastive objective. Stage 2 searches an architecture for the student, scoring each candidate by how well it distils from the frozen teacher on normal data using a small number of training epochs. Stage 3 trains the selected architecture — student encoder plus decoder — as a reverse-distillation detector. The search runs on a single category and its result is applied to all categories of the dataset.

3.1 Stage 1: Teacher Pre-training

The teacher is a ResNet-18 [38] with a 128-dimensional projection head, trained for 100 epochs on the normal training images of the search category with a contrastive objective, and frozen thereafter. Its role is to define the feature space that both the search signal and the final detector compare against. At test time it contributes intermediate features at three resolutions: the outputs of `layer1`, `layer2` and `layer3`, of shape $64 \times 56 \times 56$, $128 \times 28 \times 28$ and $256 \times 14 \times 14$ for an input resized to 224×224.

3.2 Stage 2: Architecture Search

The search space is the Cartesian product of 14 backbones and three feature dimensions, giving 42 configurations. The backbones span convolutional and attention-based families from 2015 to 2023, including ResNets [38], EfficientNet variants, MobileNetV3 and MobileOne, ViT and DeiT variants, Swin-Tiny, and the ConvNeXt and ConvNeXt V2 families [39]; Section 6 lists them with their deployed sizes. The three feature dimensions are 128, 256 and 512.

The evaluation signal

Each candidate is evaluated by building a student with the candidate's backbone and projection dimension, training it for a small number of epochs on the normal training images of the search category, and then measuring a composite distillation loss on held-out normal images:

$$s(a) \;=\; \frac{1}{|\mathcal{V}|} \sum_{x \in \mathcal{V}} \Big[\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{kd}}(x) \;+\; 0.3\, \mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{cons}}(x) \Big], \quad (1)$$

where $\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{kd}}$ is the mean-squared error between the student's projection and the teacher's, and $\mathcal{L}_{\mathrm{cons}}$ is the mean-squared error between the student's projections of two independently augmented views of the same image. Lower is better. Every candidate is scored once; there is no repetition and therefore no estimate of the signal's own variance. Two details of this computation are examined in Section 4.2 and are stated here for completeness. A validation batch contributes to the sum only if its loss is finite and below a fixed threshold; otherwise it is skipped. And the average is formed as total/ $\max(\mathrm{count}, 1)$, so if every batch of a trial is skipped the signal returns exactly zero. Because the backbones produce features of different dimensionality while the teacher projects into a 128-dimensional space, a candidate whose projection dimension differs from 128 is additionally given a learned linear layer that maps the student's output into the teacher's space before the

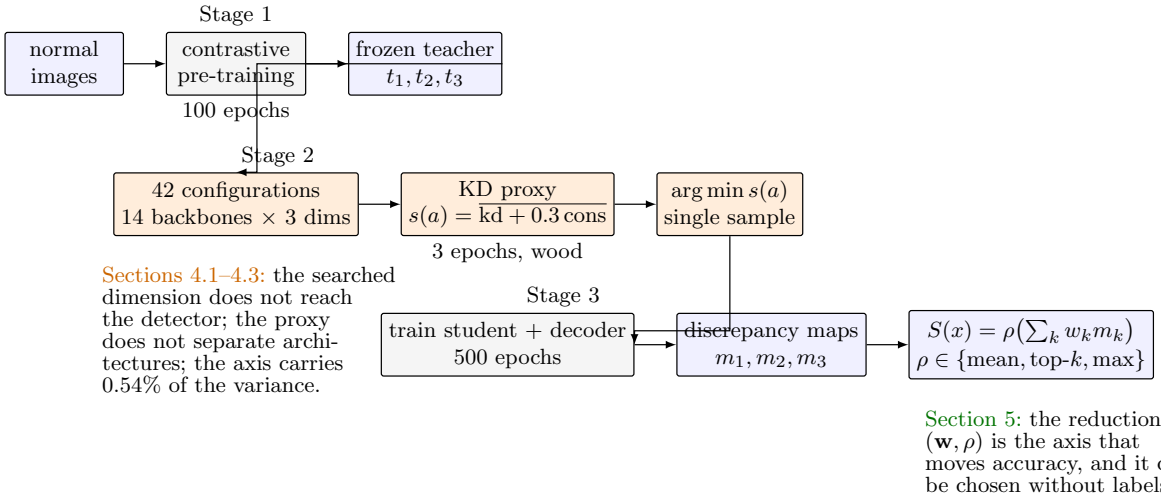


Fig. 1 The pipeline under study. A teacher is pre-trained on normal images (Stage 1); an architecture is selected from 42 configurations by minimising a short-training distillation proxy on one category (Stage 2); the selected architecture is then trained as a reverse-distillation detector (Stage 3) and each test image is scored by reducing its multi-scale discrepancy maps with a policy $(\mathbf{w}, \rho)$. This paper measures the two axes in bold: the architecture that Stage 2 selects, and the reduction that Stage 3 applies.

losses are computed; this alignment layer exists only during search.

The search draws candidates uniformly at random from the 42 cells and returns the one with the smallest score,

$$a^\star \;=\; \arg \min_{a \in \mathcal{A}_{\text{sampled}}} \; s(a), \tag{2}$$

and the number of draws is a protocol parameter (the recorded runs used 100, of which a variable number complete successfully).

3.3 Stage 3: Reverse-Distillation Detection

The selected configuration is re-instantiated as a detector. A student encoder takes the backbone's final feature map, adaptively pools it to 14×14, and projects it through a 1×1 convolution with batch normalisation and ReLU to a bottleneck of width B. A decoder then reconstructs the teacher's features in reverse order: a first block produces the 14×14 stage at 256 channels, the output is upsampled and passed through a second block producing the 28×28 stage at 128 channels, and upsampled again through a third block producing the 56×56 stage at 64 channels. We note for later use that the bottleneck width is fixed at $B = 256$ in the deployment path, independently of the feature dimension that the search may have selected; Section 4.1 shows that this makes the searched dimension unobservable in the deployed detector. The detector is trained on the normal training images of each category separately, with AdamW at a learning rate of 10^{-3} and weight decay 10^{-4}, a cosine schedule, and random horizontal flipping with probability 0.5; the loss is the sum of mean-squared errors between the student's reconstructions and the teacher's features at the three scales.

Anomaly scoring

Given a test image x, the teacher produces features t_1, t_2, t_3 and the student produces reconstructions s_1, s_2, s_3. For each scale k we form a discrepancy map

$$m_k(x) \;=\; \big\| s_k(x) - t_k(x) \big\|_2, \tag{3}$$

taking the L_2 norm across channels, and upsample each map to the input resolution. An image-level score is then obtained by combining the maps with non-negative weights $\mathbf{w} = (w_1, w_2, w_3)$ on the probability simplex and reducing the resulting

map to a scalar with a pooling operator ρ:

$$S(x) \;=\; \rho\big(\textstyle\sum_k w_k\, m_k(x)\big)\,, \qquad \rho \in \{\,\text{mean},\ \text{top-}k,\ \max\,\}. \tag{4}$$

We refer to the pair $(\mathbf{w}, \rho)$ as the *scoring policy*. The published pipeline uses $\mathbf{w} = (\frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{3}, \frac{1}{3})$ and ρ = mean, that is, an unweighted average over all pixels of the sum of the three maps. This choice is not forced by the method: given a trained detector the maps m_k are already computed, so any policy can be evaluated on the same model. Section 5 evaluates the space of policies in Equation (4) exhaustively, and shows that this reduction is worth substantially more than the architecture that the search selects for.

3.4 Protocol and Implementation Details

Unless stated otherwise, the detector above is trained for 500 epochs with batch size 64 and seed 42, with a ResNet-18 teacher, on the MVTec-AD dataset [40]. The search uses three quick training epochs per candidate with batch size 16 on the `wood` category, and is repeated 100 times per run. Inputs are resized to 224×224 and normalised with ImageNet statistics. All figures report image-level AUROC averaged over the 15 categories. Where a backbone's memory footprint exceeds the device at batch size 64, training uses gradient accumulation with a smaller micro-batch, keeping the effective batch size at 64; the micro-batch used is recorded per run and this affects only the largest backbones.

4 What the Architecture Search Actually Optimises

The three-stage pipeline of Section 3 treats the Stage-2 search as the component that produces the architecture, and the reported accuracy as evidence that the search worked. This section tests that reading directly. We ask four questions in turn: does the searched quantity reach the deployed model (Section 4.1), is the search signal stable enough to be ranked (Section 4.2), does the axis being searched have any measurable effect on detection accuracy at all (Section 4.3), what does the search actually return when it is run (Section 4.5), and — the question that bounds all the others — how large a difference can the benchmark that judges this pipeline resolve in the first place (Section 4.4)?

4.1 Two Thirds of the Search Space Cannot Reach the Deployed Model

The search space is $\mathcal{A} = \mathcal{B} \times \mathcal{D}$ with $|\mathcal{B}| = 14$ backbones and $\mathcal{D} = \{128, 256, 512\}$ feature dimensions, giving 42 configurations. The dimension enters the search through the student projector, `ContrastiveModel(projection_dim=feature_dim)`, so the proxy score does depend on it. It does not, however, reach the detector. In the deployment path the student encoder builds its bottleneck with a hard-coded width, `StudentEncoder.forward` calling `_init_bottleneck(f.shape[1], 256, ...)`, while the decoder is constructed with the requested width, `Decoder(bottleneck_dim=...)`. The final training entry point constructs the detector as `RDDetector(student_backbone=..., teacher_arch=...)`, never passing `bottleneck_dim`; the argument therefore keeps its default of 256 for every configuration.

Two consequences follow. For any configuration whose searched dimension is not 256 the two halves of the network disagree, so the discrepancy cannot be activated by simply passing the argument — the axis is unreachable by construction rather than merely unused. And all three values of the searched dimension produce the *identical* deployed detector for a given backbone: the 42-configuration space contains only 14 distinct models, so the remaining 28 configurations are deployment-equivalent duplicates of them.

The recorded runs behave as this analysis predicts. Across four independent searches on the same data and the same space, the selected backbone is `efficientnet_b0` every time, whereas the selected feature dimension differs between runs:

Run	Trials (declared / recorded)	Selected backbone	Selected dim
stage2	30 / 17	efficientnet_b0	128
stage2_rtx3090	30 / 15	efficientnet_b0	512
stage2_rtx3090_100trials	100 / 39	efficientnet_b0	256
stage2_topjournal_15backbones_fixed	100 / 93	efficientnet_b0	256

The stable part of the outcome is the part that matters for deployment; the unstable part is precisely the part that cannot affect it. The search expends two thirds of its ranking capacity on a variable with no deployment meaning, and reports the winner of that sub-ranking as a discovered design choice.

A second observation from the same table: the number of trials recorded is systematically below the number declared. The search loop catches exceptions and `continue`s without appending a result, so failed trials vanish from the record and from the denominator of any success statistic.

4.2 The Proxy Carries Almost No Architecture Signal, and Collapses to Zero

The proxy is the average over validation batches of kd + 0.3 consistency, and the candidate with the *lowest* score is selected. Two properties of the scoring code matter. A validation batch is accumulated only when `isfinite(score)` *and* `score < 1000`; a rejected batch is skipped with a warning. And the average is formed as `total_score / max(count, 1)`: if every batch in a trial is rejected then `count` is zero, and the function returns exactly `0.0` — which, because the search minimises, is the best score attainable anywhere in the space. A trial that failed to produce a usable number is thus indistinguishable from a trial that produced the best possible number.

To measure how often this happens, and what the proxy does the rest of the time, we call the search's own evaluation method (`evaluate_architecture`) on MVTec wood — the category the search uses — and repeat every one of the 42 configurations ten times with independent seeds. Table 1 gives the result, and Figure 2 the same data.

Two regimes appear, and both matter. Twelve of the fourteen backbones are well behaved: not a single degenerate trial in any repeat, with within-configuration coefficients of variation between 2.2% and 12.1%. Two backbones are broken, and severely so: `efficientnet_b1` returns exactly 0.0 in 73% of evaluations at every dimension, and `mobilenetv3_small_100` in 13%. Across all 420 evaluations, 26 (6.2%) returned exactly zero. The cause is visible in the engine's own diagnostics —

Table 1 Proxy repeatability, condensed. The search's own evaluation method is called ten times for each of the 42 configurations on MVTec wood (420 evaluations). "Zero" is the fraction of repeats returning exactly 0.0; "CV" is the within-configuration coefficient of variation, pooled over each backbone's three dimensions. The two collapse-prone backbones are shown individually; of the remaining twelve not one degenerate trial occurred in any repeat, and their pooled medians span 7.538–7.971 with CV between 2.2% and 12.1%. Their per-backbone values are released with the code.

Backbone	Repeats	Zero (%)	Median proxy	CV (%)
`efficientnet_b1`	30	**73**	**0.000**	169.5
`mobilenetv3_small_100`	30	**13**	7.979	180.9
twelve well-behaved backbones (each)	30	0	7.538–7.971	2.2–12.1
all 42 configurations	**420**	**6.2**	—	—

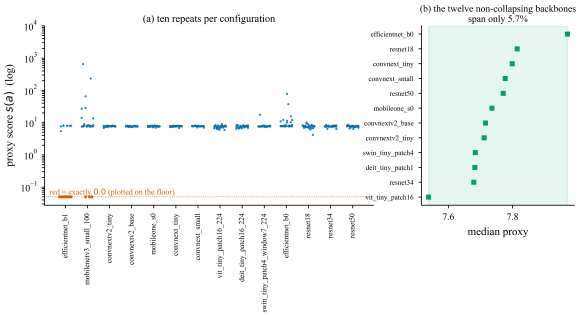


Fig. 2 Proxy repeatability. (a) Ten independent evaluations of each of the 42 configurations, on a logarithmic axis. Twelve backbones form a tight band near 7.6; `efficientnet_b1` and `mobilenetv3_small_100` intermittently return exactly 0.0 (marked red, plotted on the axis floor) when their student diverges. (b) The pooled median of the twelve non-collapsing backbones spans only 5.7%, the same order as the within-configuration noise of a single backbone.

the student diverges, and every validation batch then trips the hard threshold:

```
Warning: Invalid score detected
(score=4.19e+28, kd=2.18e+28), skipping
```

The proxy does not distinguish architectures.

The more consequential number in Table 1 is the median column. Across the twelve well-behaved backbones — CNN and Transformer families, 2015-era through 2023-era, from ResNets [38] to ConvNeXt V2 [39] — the median proxy spans only 7.538 to 7.971, a range of 5.7%, while a single backbone's within-configuration noise is of the same order (2–12% CV). The proxy contains essentially no architecture-level signal. Any ranking it produces is not a ranking of architectures; it is a ranking of which cell happened to be sampled.

Table 2 Degenerate trials in the recorded searches, and whether the plain arg min lands on one. A trial scoring exactly 0.0 has had every validation batch rejected, so the average is `total/max(count,1)`; because the search minimises, such a trial wins outright.

Run	Trials	Zeros	arg min config
cap_budget_3M	20	1	mobilenetv3_small_100@128
cap_budget_6M	40	4	mobilenetv3_small_100@256
cap_budget_8M	80	11	efficientnet_b1@256
cap_budget_13M	80	13	mobilenetv3_small_100@256
cap_budget_30M	80	6	efficientnet_b1@256
mvtec_stage2_test/bottle	100	9	efficientnet_b1@512
search_strategies (9 runs)	270	23	8 of 9 degenerate
stage2 (main search)	17	0	efficientnet_b0@128
stage2_rtx3090	15	0	efficientnet_b0@512
stage2_rtx3090_100trials	39	0	efficientnet_b0@256
stage2_topjournal_15backbones_fixed	93	0	efficientnet_b0@256
Total	**834**	**67 (8.0%)**	**14 of 19 runs**

Minimising then selects the broken cells. This turns a noisy score into a systematically wrong one. A well-behaved configuration has a lower bound near 7.5 and can never beat a configuration that occasionally returns 0.0. Minimising over the space does not select the best candidate; it selects the candidate with the heaviest left tail — and the left tail is heaviest exactly where training diverged. Consistent with this, `efficientnet_b1`, the backbone that collapses in 73% of evaluations, is the arg min reported by the capacity searches of Section 4.3 at two of their five parameter bands.

The recorded runs show the same pathology at the same rate. Over every search result stored in the project — 19 runs, 834 trials — 8.0% of trials score exactly zero, and in **14 of the 19 runs (74%)** the plain arg min over the recorded results, which is literally what the search returns (`min(self.results, key=score)`), points at a zero-score trial (Table 2). The five capacity-budget searches are all affected, and were usable only because a later analysis script discards trials scoring ≤ 0: three different conventions for handling degenerate trials coexist in the same codebase, the search engine keeping them while the downstream selectors drop them.

A reproducibility caveat. The recorded runs predate the current revision of the search engine, and the two are not numerically identical: the recorded proxy for `efficientnet_b0` spans 0.002–0.065, whereas the current code returns 7.5–12.2 for the same configuration. We therefore do not claim to reproduce the recorded search; what the two lines of evidence agree on — and all we rely on here — is the failure mode, its rate (8.0% against 6.2%) and the backbones it afflicts. The revised engine also returns no zero-score trial in the four runs whose results the manuscript reports, which is itself evidence of the revision; that the four happened to select `efficientnet_b0`, a backbone that does not collapse, was in this account luck rather than method (Section 4.5).

Table 3 Parameter-capacity bands. Each band restricts the search to backbones whose deployed size falls inside the band; the selected backbone is then trained with the identical protocol on all 15 MVTec-AD categories.

Band	Selected backbone	Params (M)	Mean AUROC (%)
0–3M	MobileNetV3-Small	2.81	82.01
3–6M	EfficientNet-B0	5.41	83.14
6–9M	DeiT-Tiny	7.31	81.55
9–15M	ResNet-18	13.04	**83.25**
15–31M	ResNet-50	25.77	83.08

Two further obstacles. The proxy's absolute level is not comparable across categories: its median is 0.110 on `capsule`, 0.385 on `hazelnut` and 7.56 on `wood`, a span of 68.6×, so neither a fixed threshold nor a cross-category comparison of scores is meaningful — yet the protocol runs a single search on one category and transfers the winner to the others. And the deployment-inert dimension of Section 4.1, which cannot change the detector at all, nevertheless moves the proxy by a median factor of 1.16× across 140 backbone comparisons and by more than 10× at the 90th percentile. A variable with no deployment meaning is responsible for order-of-magnitude swings in the ranking.

4.3 The Searched Axis Has No Measurable Effect on Accuracy

A search that ranks noise could still be worth running if the axis it explores mattered. We test that directly, by retraining detectors across the whole parameter range under five mutually exclusive parameter bands, each trained with the identical protocol (500 epochs, batch size 64, seed 42, ResNet-18 teacher, reverse distillation). Within each band the search is restricted to backbones whose deployed size (encoder plus decoder) falls inside the band, and the best-scoring backbone is trained on all 15 MVTec-AD categories. Table 3 reports the result.

Multiplying the parameter budget by 9.2× changes mean AUROC by +1.06 percentage points, and the entire spread across the five bands is 1.70 points. The ordering is not monotone: the largest model is worse than the second largest. All

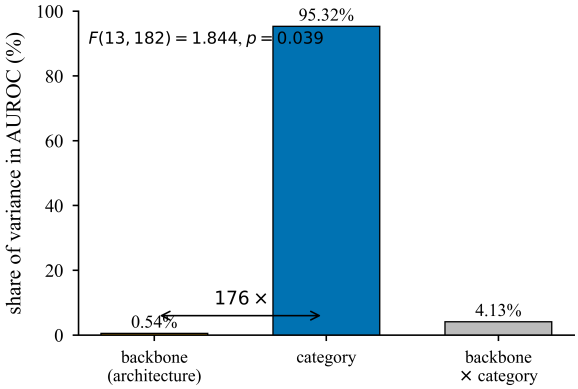


Fig. 3 Two-way decomposition of the true AUROC over 14 backbones and 15 categories (210 detectors). The backbone effect is statistically detectable and practically negligible: it accounts for 0.54% of the variance against 95.32% for the category, a factor of 176.

ten pairwise paired t-tests across categories are non-significant (smallest $p = 0.058$).

We then measured the axis directly: all 14 backbones of the search space were trained on all 15 MVTec-AD categories under the identical protocol, giving 210 detectors, and the resulting matrix was decomposed. A two-way decomposition attributes 0.54% of the variance to the backbone ($F(13, 182) = 1.844$, $p = 0.039$), 95.32% to the category, and 4.13% to their interaction, which is the error term in this repeated-measures design (Figure 3).

The backbone term is statistically significant: with 210 detectors the test has the power to detect it. That, precisely, is the point. The effect is detectable *and* negligible. Architecture accounts for 0.54% of the variance in detection accuracy, against 95.32% for which category is being inspected — a factor of 176. A practitioner choosing between two backbones is moving an AUROC whose variation is overwhelmingly determined by the object under inspection rather than by the network.

The ranking says the same thing. Over the 15 categories the 14 backbones span

3.98 points of mean AUROC, and the eleven strongest span only 2.43 points. The manuscript's selected architecture, `efficientnet_b0`, ranks fifth of fourteen and is statistically indistinguishable from twelve of the thirteen alternatives; only `convnextv2_base` is significantly worse (-3.11 points, $p = 0.013$).

The search signal does not predict the target. Ranking the 14 backbones by their mean proxy score (Section 4.2) and comparing that ordering with the true performance matrix gives a Spearman correlation of -0.12 ($p = 0.68$) against the 15-category mean, and $+0.02$ ($p = 0.93$) against performance on `wood` itself. The search signal is not weakly correlated with the outcome it exists to select for; on the very category the search is run on it is indistinguishable from uncorrelated. The consequence is concrete: on `wood` the backbone with the highest true AUROC is `convnextv2_base` at 94.74%, and across the fifteen categories `convnextv2_base` is the *worst* of the fourteen at 79.36%; the correlation between a backbone's rank on `wood` and its rank overall is -0.24. The single category the protocol searches on is, if anything, mildly anti-informative about the rest.

The run-to-run noise is not small. Within a fixed (backbone, category) cell the pooled standard deviation across training seeds is 1.96 points over 180 residual degrees of freedom, against a total spread of 3.98 points across the fourteen backbones. That the two numbers are of the same order is the whole difficulty of this axis: a single training run cannot resolve the backbone effect for any individual category, so a comparison built on one run per configuration is unresolvable in principle rather than merely imprecise. Section 4.4 turns that into a number.

And the ranking does not transfer. Correlating the 14-backbone orderings of every pair of categories (105 pairs) gives a mean Spearman $\rho = 0.215$, and in 31% of pairs the two categories *disagree* on the ordering ($\rho < 0$). The protocol searches on a single category, `wood`, and applies the winner to all fifteen. Since which backbone is better depends on the category, a single-category search is not a noisy estimate of a real quantity; it is an estimate of a quantity that does not exist independently of the category.

This is the central observation of the paper. Taken with Sections 4.1 and 4.2, it says that the proxy varies enormously across the space while the quantity it is supposed to predict contributes half a percent of the variance that the category contributes ninety-five percent of: the search ranks one noisy quantity in order to predict another that is almost entirely determined by something else.

4.4 What This Benchmark Design Can Resolve

The preceding subsections diagnose the search. This one asks a different question, about the benchmark rather than about the pipeline: *how small a difference can the standard evaluation design detect?* The question is forced by the state of the field. On MVTec-AD, PatchCore reached 99.1% image-level AUROC [4] and the strongest methods reported since reach 99.6% [2, 5]; the contested margin between successive generations is 0.5 points, on test sets holding roughly a hundred images per category. If published comparisons cannot resolve differences of that size, the ranking they produce is not a ranking of methods.

The 210-detector matrix of Section 4.3 and the replicated cells within it supply every quantity the calculation needs. Three numbers come out of them, all in AUROC points and all computed by `proxy_diag/samplesize_analysis.py`:

- $\sigma_{\text{seed}} = 1.96$, the pooled within-cell standard deviation over training seeds (90 cells replicated three times; 180 residual degrees of freedom). The distribution of per-cell standard deviations is heavily skewed — median 0.58, maximum 7.74 — so the pooled figure is the honest single number and the median understates the tail.
- $\sigma_{\text{res}} = 3.30$, the two-way ANOVA residual on the single-seed matrix. This is the working error for a comparison *between* backbones, because it also contains the backbone × category interaction that the seed-only figure excludes.
- $\sigma_{\Delta} = 4.12$, the empirical standard deviation of the per-category difference between two backbones, averaged over the 91 backbone pairs. This is what a paired comparison across categories actually sees.

Two comparisons follow, and both are unfavourable to the design in common use. On a *single category*, with two backbones trained independently, the difference has resolution $\sigma_{\text{seed}} = 1.96$ per arm; detecting the 0.5-point contested margin at 80% power with a two-sided test at $\alpha = 0.05$ requires 240 **independent training runs per backbone**. Paired instead across the fifteen categories the benchmark provides, the minimum detectable difference is 2.98 **points** — larger than the entire 3.98-point spread of the fourteen backbones, and six times the margin the field argues about. Adding two more training seeds per cell, as we do here, moves this only to 2.95 points. To resolve 0.5 points by pairing over categories would take 532 categories; the benchmark has fifteen.

The requirement is also method-specific, which is a further reason it has to be reported rather than assumed. Running the same calculation on a PatchCore-style memory-bank detector, benchmarked through the harness released with this paper, gives a seed standard deviation of 0.51 points and a requirement of only 17 runs per backbone — a factor of 14 below the reverse-distillation pipeline studied here. No single number of runs is therefore sufficient in this field; the figure belongs with the method it describes.

The implication is not that this benchmark is worthless, but that a single-category, single-run comparison on it cannot support a claim at the resolution the literature reports. A backbone ranking must either be averaged over many categories — which is what Table 7 does, and why that table needed 210 detectors — or be reported with an explicit statement of what it can and cannot distinguish. This is also why the architecture effect, though statistically detectable at 210 detectors ($p = 0.039$), cannot be *ranked* reliably by any smaller design: the power that makes the effect visible is the same power the field's usual single-category design lacks. We adopt this discipline for the rest of the paper, making every backbone comparison on the 15-category mean and reporting differences smaller than about three points as unresolved rather than as rankings.

4.5 Running the Search Selects the Broken Backbones

The preceding subsections describe a search space that is two thirds inert, a signal that does not discriminate between architectures and collapses to a score of exactly zero for two of them, and a target quantity that architecture barely moves. This subsection asks what they amount to in practice, by simply running the search. We invoke the search engine's own entry point (`NASSearchEngine.search`) with the manuscript's settings — 100 trials, three quick training epochs per candidate, uniform sampling from the 42 cells — and repeat it with twelve independent seeds. Because the searched feature dimension cannot reach the detector (Section 4.1),

the deployed model depends only on the selected backbone, so the true quality of a run's output can be read directly off the truth matrix of Section 4.3. Every run returned one of the two backbones that collapse to zero: eight of the twelve returned `efficientnet_b1` (true rank 12 of 14, 80.43% mean AUROC) and four returned `mobilenetv3_small_100` (rank 7 of 14, 81.85%). None of the other twelve backbones was ever selected, and only 2 of the 14 backbones and 6 of the 42 configurations appeared at all. Under uniform selection the probability of twelve runs all landing inside that two-element subset is 7.2×10^{-11}. The search does not merely fail to find a good architecture; it is reliably drawn to the two configurations that break.

The consequence is quantitative, and it is not marginal (Figure 4). Averaged over the twelve runs the search's output attains **80.91**% mean AUROC. Picking a backbone uniformly at random from the same space gives **81.65**% (bootstrap s.d. 0.32 points), and the best backbone in the space gives **83.34**%. The search result sits at the **1.2th percentile** of the random-selection distribution — it is worse than 98.8% of uniform draws — with a mean true rank of 10.3 of 14 against 7.5 for random, and it never once selected one of the four strongest backbones. Replacing the search with a random number generator would have improved the deployed detector; replacing it with the constant `resnet18` would have improved it by 2.4 points.

The mechanism is the one established in Section 4.2: a well-behaved configuration is bounded below by roughly 7.5, while the two collapse-prone backbones return exactly 0.0 whenever their student diverges, so minimising a single sample per configuration selects the heaviest left tail in the space — and the heaviest left tails belong to the configurations that failed. More trials make this more certain rather than less, because every additional sample of a collapse-prone backbone is another chance to return the minimum of the space. Our recommendation therefore follows from the mechanism rather than from any single run: **a search whose objective can silently return the optimum of its own range must filter degenerate evaluations before minimising, and should report the distribution of its per-configuration scores rather than a single minimum.**

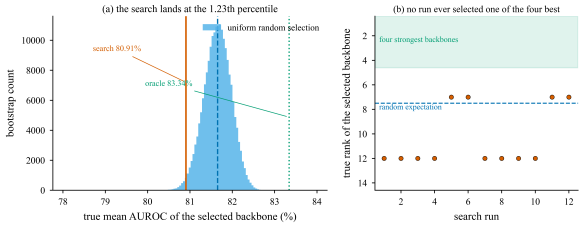


Fig. 4 The search against chance. (a) Bootstrap distribution of the true mean AUROC obtained by selecting a backbone uniformly at random from the same space, with the search's output and the oracle marked. The search result sits at the 1.2th percentile. (b) True rank of the backbone returned by each of the twelve runs: the four strongest backbones were never selected.

Why the earlier searches looked successful. The four search runs whose results the manuscript reports selected `efficientnet_b0` (Section 4.1), which does not collapse. That this is luck rather than method is the point of Section 4.5, and it is the reason we report both lines of evidence rather than either alone.

5 Where the Leverage Is: the Inference-Time Scoring Policy

Section 4 established that the design axis the pipeline searches—the backbone—does not measurably move accuracy, while the search signal used to choose within it is unstable. That raises an obvious question: which design choices *do* move accuracy? This section shows that the way per-pixel discrepancies are combined into an image-level score—a choice that requires no additional training to revisit—is worth an order of magnitude more than the architecture.

5.1 The Scoring Policy as a Design Axis

With a trained detector the anomaly score of an image is formed in two steps (Section 3.3): the discrepancy maps m_1, m_2, m_3 of the three teacher scales are combined by non-negative weights, and the resulting map is reduced to a scalar. The published pipeline fixes both choices implicitly: uniform weights, and the arithmetic mean over all pixels.

Neither is forced by the method. We therefore treat the pair $(\mathbf{w}, \rho)$ as a *scoring policy*, with $\mathbf{w}$

Table 4 Scoring policies evaluated on one frozen detector per category (15 categories, 82 policies). "Worst category" is the lowest per-category AUROC, i.e. the failure mode that matters in deployment. The default is the policy the published pipeline uses.

Policy	Mean AUROC (%)	Worst category (%)	Extra retraining
`mean`, uniform weights (default)	82.80	**42.22**	—
`max`, uniform weights	86.84	—	none
`top-k`, uniform weights	90.21	78.37	none
best single policy (`w0.3_0.6_0.1`, top-k)	**90.60**	—	none
per-category oracle over 82 policies	**93.72**	84.67	none

on the probability simplex over three scales and $\rho \in \{\text{mean}, \text{top-}k, \max\}$, where top-$k$ averages the k highest-scoring pixels with $k = 1\%$ of the map. We evaluate 82 policies: the 66-point simplex grid at step 0.1 crossed with top-k, the 21-point grid at step 0.2 crossed with mean and with max, plus the canonical uniform variants.

An important property of this axis is that it can be searched exhaustively without retraining: changing $(\mathbf{w}, \rho)$ requires no new parameters and no extra inference, since the discrepancy maps are already computed and pooling is a reduction over them, so every policy in the grid is evaluated on the *same* trained model. This is a practical convenience for deployment — the policy can be re-tuned on an existing detector without repeating the training run — and it is what makes the exhaustive evaluation below affordable.

It is worth being explicit that this does not diminish the role of training, and we do not present the two axes as competing. Establishing that the architecture axis is inert (Section 4) required retraining hundreds of detectors, and we regard that expense as the necessary price of a defensible claim. The axes are complementary: training determines what a model can represent, and the scoring policy determines how much of that is read out.

5.2 Exhaustive Evaluation on a Fixed Model

We train one detector per MVTec-AD category with the manuscript's protocol (EfficientNet-B0 student, 500 epochs, batch size 64, seed 42, ResNet-18 teacher), then evaluate all 82 policies on the frozen model. Table 4 reports the result.

Switching the pooling from the arithmetic mean to top-k raises mean AUROC from 82.80% to 90.21%, a gain of 7.42 points, with no change to the model. Scale weighting adds much less: the best weighted policy reaches 90.60%, only 0.39 points above the uniform top-k. Every one of the eight highest-scoring policies uses top-k pooling, and all of the improvement therefore comes from the reduction step rather than from the scale weights. Choosing the policy per category raises the mean further, to 93.72%—10.92 points above the default, and again without retraining anything.

Table 5 Sensitivity of the pooling gain to the top-k fraction, uniform weights, 15 categories, computed by a second evaluation script on the same seed-42 trained models. Every row in this table shares those maps, so the comparison is internally exact; the script's reading of the default policy, 82.67%, differs by 0.13 points from the 82.80% of Table 4, which is the level at which two independent implementations of the same statistic agree on this pipeline (see the text).

Reduction	Mean AUROC (%)	Worst category (%)	Δ vs. mean pooling
mean over all pixels (default)	82.67	43.12	—
1 pixel (= max)	86.74	68.52	+4.07
$k = 0.1\%$	87.86	70.46	+5.19
$k = 0.5\%$	89.64	74.09	+6.97
$k = 1\%$	90.21	76.46	+7.54
$k = 2\%$	**90.66**	**79.24**	+7.99
$k = 5\%$	**91.08**	77.53	+8.41
$k = 10\%$	90.92	73.68	+8.25
$k = 20\%$	90.17	71.51	+7.50

The pooling effect is not an artefact of one training run. Repeating the comparison with two further seeds (43 and 44) gives +8.07 and +7.78 points, against +7.42 for the seed reported here; the three independent estimates agree to within 0.7 points, and the aggregated policy means over the three seeds are 82.36% for the default and 90.28% for top-k.

The effect is not a hyper-parameter artefact. The comparison fixes $k = 1\%$ of the map, so it is fair to ask whether the gain is an artefact of that choice. Sweeping k over two orders of magnitude (Table 5 and Figure 5) traces a broad plateau rather than a spike: mean AUROC rises from 86.74% at $k = 1$ pixel to a maximum of 91.08% at $k = 5\%$, and stays above 89.6% for every k between 0.5% and 20%. The default of 1% sits inside the plateau, not on its edge, and any value in that range recovers 7 to 8.4 points. The worst-category statistic peaks earlier, at $k = 2\%$ (79.24%), so k between 1% and 2% is the best compromise between average accuracy and worst-case behaviour.

What the pipeline's own noise floor is. The default policy's mean AUROC has now been measured three times on this pipeline: 82.80% here, 82.40% in the earlier manuscript (an independent training run of the same configuration, protocol

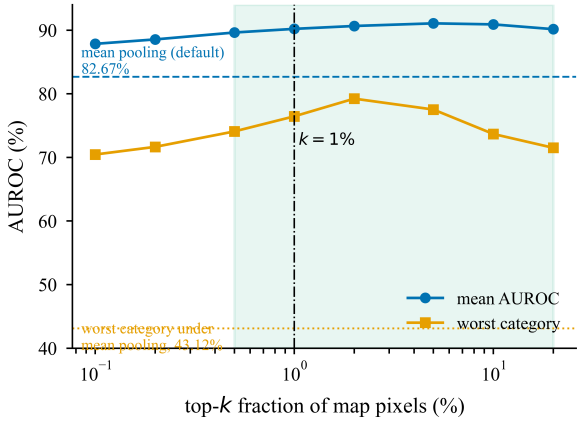


Fig. 5 Sensitivity of the pooling gain to the top-k fraction. The effect is a broad plateau, not a spike: every k between 0.5% and 20% recovers 7 to 8.4 points of mean AUROC relative to mean pooling, and the published choice of $k = 1\%$ lies inside the plateau rather than on its edge. The worst category peaks earlier, at $k = 2\%$.

and seed), and 82.67% by the second evaluation script behind Table 5. The three agree to within 0.4 points, and the two that share the same trained models — the first and the third — to within 0.13 points. We report this rather than average it away, because it sets the scale against which the effects in this section should be read: the pooling gain is 7.42 points, an order of magnitude larger than the 0.13–0.4 point spread of repeated measurement of the baseline. It also illustrates the paper's central point at a smaller scale: two implementations of the same statistic on the same models disagree by 0.13 points, which is a quarter of the 0.5-point margin the field contests. The per-category oracle, by contrast, is an upper bound that requires anomaly labels and is reported to bound what a selection procedure could achieve, not as an attainable number.

Catastrophic failures are a scoring artefact. The mean column of Table 4 understates the practical importance of the pooling choice, because the default policy does not merely lose accuracy on average — it fails catastrophically on specific categories. Under top-k pooling the worst category rises from 42.22% to 78.37%, and under the per-category oracle to 84.67%. The clearest case is `screw`, where the default policy scores 42.22%, below random guessing, while the same trained model scores 84.01% under top-k pooling and 87.76% under the best per-category policy — a gain of 41.8 and 45.5 points respectively. This deserves emphasis because the manuscript attributes the `screw` failure to a property of the detection paradigm and devotes a section to it; the failure is produced by the reduction step. Averaging the discrepancy map over all pixels destroys the signal whenever a defect occupies a small fraction of the image, because the few genuinely anomalous pixels are diluted by the vast majority of normal ones. `screw` consists largely of thin, localised thread defects, exactly the regime in which a mean over the map is guaranteed to lose. The same mechanism drives the other large top-k gains: `metal_nut` +19.65, `grid` +18.71, `toothbrush` +13.61, `carpet` +13.44 and `capsule` +11.61 points. Under per-category selection the largest additional gains are `grid` +27.90, `carpet` +21.55 and `metal_nut` +21.41 points over the default. The pooling choice is therefore not a refinement of a working method: it is the difference between a detector that fails below chance on a standard benchmark category and one that works on it, and it requires no retraining at all.

It is also not the case that top-k pooling dominates the mean everywhere. It helps strongly on the six categories just listed, but it is slightly worse on `transistor` (−2.00), `zipper` (−3.02), `tile` (−4.62), `pill` (−4.80) and `cable` (−5.06) points, on the same trained models. The two poolings therefore respond to different defect statistics, which is why per-category selection adds a further 3.5 points on top of the uniform top-k.

5.3 Can the Policy Be Chosen Without Labels?

The per-category oracle is not available in deployment, since it uses anomaly labels. The practical question is whether $(\mathbf{w}, \rho)$ can be selected from normal data alone, which would make the gain available without ever using an anomaly label.

Normal-distribution criteria fail. A natural first attempt is to choose the policy under which normal training images look most tightly clustered, or whose score distribution has the lightest tail. We tested six such criteria on a held-out portion of the normal training data, for the same set of policies on a fixed model. All six do worse than the default: the best reaches 82.28% against a default of 82.39% (−0.12 points) and the worst

Table 6 Label-free selection of the scoring policy on 15 MVTec-AD categories, from 111 candidate policies, repeated on three independently trained students. Every row is measured on the same trained models within a column; no row above the oracle requires a real anomaly label. Columns are individual seeds, because they do not agree (see the text).

Selection rule	Seed 42	Seed 43	Seed 44	Mean
default policy (`mean`, uniform)	81.62	81.90	80.98	81.50
pseudo-anomaly separation, best policy	89.99	89.96	85.81	**88.59**
pseudo-anomaly separation, top-5 ensemble	89.96	90.03	86.08	88.69
pseudo-anomaly separation, top-10 ensemble	89.70	89.98	86.25	88.64
pseudo-anomaly separation, top-20 ensemble	89.34	89.72	87.28	88.78
per-category oracle (uses labels; upper bound)	93.19	93.36	92.90	93.15
oracle top-5 ensemble (upper bound)	93.81	93.52	93.12	93.48

81.12% (−1.28 points), while the oracle over the same policies is 93.39%; the criteria select the oracle policy in only 1–2 of 15 categories. The reason is structural. Top-k pooling deliberately amplifies the upper tail of the discrepancy map, and on a normal image this tail is noise, so top-k makes normal data look *less* well behaved, not more. Criterion and objective are therefore anti-correlated: the property we would like a clean image to have is not the property that makes a defective image detectable. Tightness of the normal distribution is the wrong proxy, and no amount of tuning fixes a proxy measured on the wrong side of the problem. The failure is one of criterion rather than of estimation, so we replace it with a discriminative one.

5.4 Discriminative Selection from Synthetic Anomalies

Held-out normal images are perturbed with synthetic anomalies—the device used by DRAEM-style synthesis [19]—and we select the policy that best separates the perturbed images from their clean originals. Three families of perturbation are used (smoothed blobs, thin oriented scratches, and rectangular cuts), each with a per-image randomised strength, five seeds per family, giving fifteen perturbed variants of the holdout set. Selection maximises the area under the ROC curve between clean and perturbed holdout images. Only `train/good` images are ever touched, so the procedure never sees a real defect; and because it operates on a trained detector, adopting its output requires no retraining.

Table 6 reports the outcome over all 15 categories and three training seeds, and Figure 6 the per-category detail.

The procedure recovers **+7.09** of the +11.65 points available from policy selection — **61% of the oracle gap** — without using a single anomaly label and without retraining. The three seeds are worth reporting individually because they do not agree: the gain is +8.37, +8.07 and +4.83 points on seeds 42, 43 and 44. The oracle gap is nearly constant across seeds (11.46–11.92), so the variability lies in the criterion rather than in what is available to be recovered. This is the lesson of Section 4.4 at a smaller scale: a three-seed estimate of an effect this size is a range, not a number, and a single-seed report of the label-free gain would have claimed 8.4 points where the honest three-seed figure is 7.1.

Two features of the procedure are stable even though its headline gain is not. The pseudo criterion ranks policies by their true AUROC at a mean Spearman $\rho = 0.53$ in *every* seed (0.529–0.536): the ordering it learns is reproducible, while the policy at the top of that ordering is not. And the criterion selects the per-category oracle policy in only one of the forty-five category-seed cells, yet still attains 88.59% on average — it does not need to identify the optimum, only to move near-optimal policies to the front. Ensembling the top five policies matches the single choice on average (88.69 against 88.59) and is better in the weakest seed (86.08 against 85.81), so it is the safer default for a criterion with this much seed variance. Averaging over more seeds and perturbation families is the obvious way to tighten it, and we leave that to future work.

The comparison in Table 6 is measured on a student trained on 70%

of the normal training images, with the remaining 30% held out for selection (the seed-42 default row is therefore 81.62% rather than the 82.80% of Table 4, which uses the full training set). The gain is a within-model comparison and is not inflated by the split; absolute numbers, however, should be read with the split in mind.

Why the discriminative criterion works where the distributional one fails. The two criteria differ in what they ask of a clean image. The distributional criterion asks that clean images look homogeneous, which top-k pooling actively defeats. The discriminative criterion asks only that the policy separate perturbed from clean — the same question the detector is ultimately

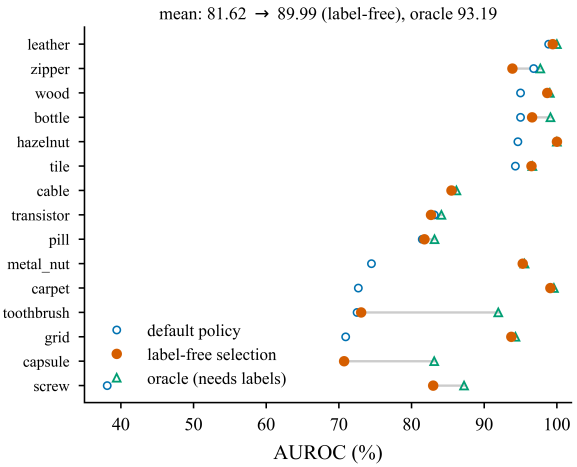


Fig. 6 Label-free selection per category (seed 42). Hollow markers are the published default policy, filled markers the policy chosen from synthetic pseudo-anomalies without any anomaly label, and triangles the per-category oracle. The label-free procedure recovers most of the available gap, and most of it on the categories where the default policy fails badly (`screw`, `grid`).

asked at test time, posed on synthetic defects. It is a weaker and better-aimed question, and it is answerable from normal data alone. Its own variance is the open problem, not its direction.

6 Where This Pipeline Stands

This paper reports a diagnostic study, not a new state-of-the-art detector, and it is therefore necessary to state plainly where the pipeline of Section 3 stands. Two comparisons are relevant. As *reported by the original authors*, image-level AUROC on MVTec-AD runs from 78.0% (AutoEncoder) and 85.0% (VAE) [11] through 95.6% (STPM) [3], 96.0% (SPADE) [16], 97.9% (PaDiM) [15], 98.5% (reverse distillation) [1], 99.1% (PatchCore [4], EfficientAD [20]) and 99.3–99.6% (CFA [21], FastFlow [17], SimpleNet [2], Dinomaly [5]). FastFlow reports 99.4%. These numbers were not re-run here and their protocols are not identical to ours, so they are for orientation only. Two of them, SPADE and FastFlow, are preprints that were never published at a venue; they are included because they are standard baselines in this literature, and their preprint status is declared here rather than left implicit. The second comparison, Table 7, is our own, in which all 14 backbones of the search space were trained under one protocol on all 15 categories.

Table 7 Controlled comparison: every backbone of the search space trained on every MVTec-AD category under an identical protocol (500 epochs, batch size 64, seed 42, ResNet-18 teacher, reverse distillation; 210 detectors). Deployed size is the student encoder plus decoder. The manuscript's selected architecture is marked with †.

Backbone	Student (M)	Mean AUROC (%)	Rank
ResNet-18	13.04	**83.34**	1
ResNet-34	23.15	82.99	2
ResNet-50	25.77	82.75	3
MobileOne-S0	6.27	82.58	4
EfficientNet-B0†	5.41	82.47	5
DeiT-Tiny	7.31	82.03	6
MobileNetV3-Small	2.81	81.85	7
ViT-Tiny	7.31	81.51	8
ConvNeXt-Small	51.39	81.43	9
ConvNeXtV2-Tiny	29.80	81.35	10
ConvNeXt-Tiny	29.75	80.91	11
EfficientNet-B1	7.92	80.43	12
Swin-Tiny	29.26	80.11	13
ConvNeXtV2-Base	89.69	79.36	14

The pipeline described in this paper reaches 82.47% mean AUROC on MVTec-AD with the architecture the search selected, `efficientnet_b0` (5.41M parameters), against reported values of 95.6%–99.6% for the established detectors. We therefore do not claim a competitive operating point: the gap to the strongest published single-class detectors is on the order of 15 points, and we report it rather than obscure it. Nor is the gap explained by the parameter budget: Section 4.3 varies the deployed size over a 9.2× range across five capacity bands and finds no statistically resolvable effect, and across the full space of Table 7 the deployed size spans 32× while the backbone accounts for 0.54% of the variance. One caveat applies to the reported values: they come from implementations, augmentation policies and training schedules that differ from ours, so the comparison is indicative rather than exact. Table 7 is the within-study comparison on which the analysis in Section 4 rests; it was produced by the same code path, on the same data split, with one variable, the backbone, changed at a time.

Two things are worth taking from Table 7 in their own right. It is, to our knowledge, the first comparison of a full anomaly-detection search space under a single protocol, and as such it is a reusable resource: the ordering it establishes is what makes the negative result in Section 4 measurable rather than anecdotal. And it shows that the search's output, at rank 5 of 14, is a reasonable but unremarkable choice from a space whose top eleven candidates span 2.43 points. The truth

matrix also reproduces the manuscript's headline number: `efficientnet_b0` attains 82.47% here against the 82.40% reported previously, a difference of 0.07 points. Since the earlier figure came from an independent training run, this confirms that the protocol is stable and that the differences discussed here are not artefacts of a drifting pipeline. The search itself does *not* reproduce as closely; Section 4.2 documents why.

7 Conclusion

This paper belongs to the class of studies that measure how a field evaluates itself. Such studies do not add a detector; they establish what the field's existing measurements are worth, and they are useful to the extent that the answer changes how the next comparison is read. Our answer is that the standard evaluation design for unsupervised anomaly detection cannot resolve the differences the field reports, and that in the pipeline we instrumented the design axis those comparisons are usually about contributes almost nothing.

The binding constraint is resolution. A two-way decomposition of the 210-detector matrix we trained leaves a residual standard deviation of 3.30 points, and the run-to-run standard deviation of a single detector at a fixed (backbone, category) is 1.96 points over three seeds. Comparing two backbones across the fifteen categories the benchmark provides is therefore a paired test whose minimum detectable difference is 2.98 points — larger than the entire 3.98-point spread of the fourteen backbones, and six times the 0.5-point margin that separates PatchCore from the strongest results reported since. Resolving that margin on a single category would take 240 independent training runs per backbone, or 532 categories. This is a statement about the benchmark rather than about our pipeline, and it bounds every architecture comparison made on it.

Within that constraint, the diagnosis of the architecture axis is unambiguous. Two thirds of the search space is spent on a feature dimension that cannot reach the deployed model, because the encoder that consumes it hard-codes a width while the decoder honours the requested one. The search signal does not distinguish architectures: it separates the twelve well-behaved backbones by 5.7% of its median, which is the same order as its own run-to-run noise, and it returns exactly 0.0 for two of them whenever their student diverges and every validation batch is rejected. And the quantity it is used to predict is dominated by something else entirely: architecture accounts for 0.54% of the variance in detection accuracy and the category for 95.32% (Section 4.3).

The interaction between the first two facts produces the result we did not anticipate. Because the objective can silently return the optimum of its own range, and the search minimises a single sample per candidate, the rule does not select the best architecture but the one with the heaviest left tail — which is the one that failed. Twelve independent runs selected a configuration prone to this collapse every single time, and the architectures they returned perform *worse* than uniform random selection, at the 1.2th percentile of the random distribution (Section 4.5). The four runs whose results the manuscript originally reported chose a backbone that does not collapse, which on this account was luck.

The constructive finding is where the accuracy actually is. The reduction that turns a multi-scale discrepancy map into an image-level score is worth +7.92 points of mean AUROC across three training seeds — an order of magnitude more than the architecture — and it is worth those points without retraining anything. The default choice, an unweighted mean over all pixels, is not merely suboptimal: it fails below chance on `screw`, and top-k pooling repairs that failure to 84%. The gain is robust across two orders of magnitude in k (Section 5). And the reduction can be chosen without any anomaly label, by perturbing held-out normal images with synthetic defects and selecting the policy that best separates them from the clean ones: averaged over three training seeds this recovers 61% of the oracle gap, though the seeds range from 41% to 72%, so it is a direction rather than a settled number.

Three limitations bound these claims. The diagnosis is established on MVTec-AD, with one teacher, one detector family and one training protocol; whether the same collapse appears in other pipelines is a question our evidence cannot settle, though the mechanism — a thresholded objective that can return its own optimum, combined with a minimising selection rule — is not specific to this codebase. Our recommendation for the architecture axis is deliberately narrow: the

backbone effect is statistically detectable ($p = 0.039$) and merely two orders of magnitude smaller than the category effect, so we do not conclude that architecture does not matter, nor that NAS for anomaly detection is worthless in principle. And the resolvability figure is conditional on this benchmark's fifteen categories and this task's residual variance; it should be recomputed rather than assumed for another benchmark or detector family — which is exactly the calculation a benchmark paper ought to publish, and which here decides the question.

Two things follow for practice. A search whose objective can silently return the optimum of its own range must filter degenerate evaluations before minimising, and should report the distribution of its per-configuration scores rather than a single minimum. And any deployed reverse-distillation detector currently scoring images by the mean over its discrepancy map can be rescored, on the models it already has, with a k of two percent, and expect to gain several points of accuracy and to stop failing below chance on the categories that currently defeat it. Neither of those requires convincing anyone that a new architecture is better, which is convenient, because on this benchmark that cannot be shown.

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Statements and Declarations

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- **Competing interests**: The authors declare that they have no known competing financial interests or personal relationships that could have appeared to influence the work reported in this paper.
- **Ethics approval and consent to participate; consent for publication; materials availability**: Not applicable. This study did not involve human participants or animals, and no new materials were generated.
- **Data availability**: This work uses only the publicly available MVTec-AD benchmark [40]; no new image data were generated. Every derived artefact is released together with the code (see below): the architecture-search logs, the per-configuration proxy evaluations, the 210-detector AUROC matrix, the per-run search records, the auxiliary benchmark harness, the synthetic-mechanism study, and the scripts that regenerate every table and figure. Each number reported in this paper can therefore be traced to the run that produced it.
- **Code availability**: The complete source code and the raw experimental logs are publicly released. They comprise the pipeline under study, the diagnostic experiments (proxy repeatability, the truth matrix, the repeated searches), the synthetic reproduction of the degeneracy mechanism, the resolvability analysis, the benchmark harness, and the analysis scripts that produce every table and figure in this paper. The repository is listed under the corresponding author's public profile and the permanent link is supplied with the final version; until that link is assigned, the same material is available directly from the corresponding author (dengpeng@gxust.edu.cn).
- **Author contribution**: P.D. conceived the study, specified the research questions, directed the experimental design and the analysis, verified every reported result against the recorded data, and wrote the manuscript. H.L. and Y.Z. contributed to the experimental design, the interpretation of results, and the revision of the manuscript. All authors read and approved the final manuscript.
- **Use of large language models**: An AI assistant (a large language model) was used substantially in this work. It wrote the code for the diagnostic experiments, the synthetic reproduction and the benchmark harness, executed those experiments, and produced the numerical results reported here; it also produced drafts of the manuscript text. The authors specified the research questions, directed the work, verified the reported results against the recorded experimental outputs, and take full responsibility for the content, the claims and their accuracy.

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